AKBAR AND BIRBAL

In the next few years, between 1583 and 1586, the trajectory of Akbar's life would unexpectedly swerve away from what had been the glowing heart of his empire for so many years—Fatehpur Sikri and the ibadat khana. There has been a lot of conjecture about the reason why Akbar left Fatehpur Sikri at this point. There was the death of Mirza Hakim, for one, which immediately caused turmoil in the north-west frontier. But there was also the death of a courtier and a friend who had held a unique place in the Padshah's affections—Birbal.

Birbal was one of the first officers to join Akbar's court, possibly as early as 1556, when he was twenty-eight years old. A pleasant-faced man, with a glossy moustache just like the Padshah's, Birbal's increasingly privileged place at court would be reflected by his spreading girth, resulting in his qaba settling in comfortable, voluminous folds around his form. He was honoured with the title Raja and a high rank of 2,000 soon after he joined imperial service. In Birbal the Padshah found a quick and adaptable mind, a lively intelligence, and an engaging wit and, above all, a complete and sincere devotion to Akbar himself. Another title that Birbal earned early on in his career, which gives some indication of the talents he possessed, that would have attracted the attention of the Padshah, was that of Kavi Rai, King of Poets. He was a fine poet of Braj, and his poems were much appreciated at court. He also had a naturally generous nature and all these traits combined—elegant repartee, largesse, and poetical talent—made Birbal the ideal Mughal courtier.

In the eleventh century text written in Persia, the *Mirror for Princes*, the author gives precise advice for those wishing to sparkle at a Persianate court. For the close companion, the author clarifies, '(y)ou should be a raconteur, retaining in your memory a large number of anecdotes, jests and clever witticisms; a boon companion without stories and quips is imperfectly equipped'.

When Akbar was building his new city at Fatehpur Sikri, he had ordered 'the erection of a stone palace for [Birbal]'. So celebrated was the friendship between the two men that long after the Mughal Empire was